



490.LIFE · TEACHING · STUDY GUIDE

Rightly Handling the Word

2 Timothy 2:15 · Acts 17:11 · Ezra 7:10



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LIVING THE 490 LIFE · 490.LIFE/TEACHINGS

Introduction: Every Christian Is an Interpreter

The moment you open a Bible and ask, “What does this mean?” you have become an interpreter. There is no way around it. The only question is whether you will interpret well or badly. Nobody reads the Bible without a method. Some people simply never notice theirs.

Most of us have seen what bad interpretation looks like. A verse is pulled out of a letter and stuck on a coffee mug, and it ends up promising something God never promised. A preacher builds a whole sermon on one word and gets the word wrong. A friend says, “Well, that’s just your interpretation,” as if every reading were as good as every other. Peter saw it happening in the first century. Of Paul’s letters he wrote, “There are some things in them that are hard to understand, which the ignorant and unstable twist to their own destruction, as they do the other Scriptures” (2 Pet. 3:16). The verb for “twist” is the word for wrenching a limb on a rack. You can make the Bible scream almost anything if you are willing to torture it.

But the answer to bad interpretation is not to stop interpreting. It is to interpret well. And God has not left us to guess how. The Bible itself shows us how it wants to be read. The prophets read earlier Scripture with care. Jesus argued from the exact wording of a verse. Paul reasoned in the synagogues “from the Scriptures” (Acts 17:2). The Bereans checked even the apostle’s preaching against the text, and Luke calls them noble for it (Acts 17:11).

This study is built for new believers, and for anyone who has never been taught how to study. We will go in a deliberate order, because the order matters. First the **posture**: how to come to the Book. Then the **foundation**: why the Bible can be read logically at all. Then the **tools**: reasoning, the author’s meaning, context, and Scripture interpreting Scripture. Then the **method**, step by step, with a flowchart you can print and keep in your Bible. And finally the **purpose**, because the goal of Bible study was never information. It was always a Person.

Underneath all of it is one conviction the Reformers fought for and the Westminster Confession put into words: “The infallible rule of interpretation of Scripture is the Scripture itself” (WCF 1.9). The Bible defines the Bible. Our job is to let it.

The Word: Cutting It Straight

2 Timothy 2:14–16 *“Remind them of these things, and charge them before God not to quarrel about words, which does no good, but only ruins the hearers. Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly handling the word of truth. But avoid irreverent babble, for it will lead people into more and more ungodliness.”*

Paul is writing his last letter. He is in a Roman prison, and he knows he is about to die (2 Tim. 4:6). Timothy is left in Ephesus to lead a church where false teachers are spreading. Paul names two of them a few verses later: Hymenaeus and Philetus, “who have swerved from the truth, saying that the resurrection has already happened. They are upsetting the faith of some” (2:17–18). Notice what their error was. It was not a new holy book. It was a bad reading of a true doctrine. They took the resurrection, which the apostles taught, and bent it. And it wrecked people’s faith. So Paul tells Timothy to be a different kind of worker. Here is the word he uses:

ὀρθοτομέω (*orthotomeō*)

translated “rightly handling.” To cut a straight path; to guide something straight to its goal

ὀρθός (*orthos*)

“straight, upright”

The word behind “orthodox” and “orthodontist.”
Straight, true, not bent.

+

τέμνω (*temnō*)

“to cut”

To cut or carve. Together: to cut a line that runs
straight.

Payoff: This is the only time the word appears in the New Testament, so we look for help in the Greek Old Testament the apostles read. There it shows up twice, both in Proverbs, and both times of a road. “In all your ways acknowledge him, and he will make straight your paths” (Prov. 3:6). “The righteousness of the blameless keeps his way straight” (Prov. 11:5). Scholars debate the exact picture Paul had in mind: a road crew cutting a road straight through rough country, a mason squaring a stone, a farmer plowing one true furrow. Every one of them says the same thing. The word of truth has a direction of its own. The worker’s job is not to invent a path. It is to cut along the line the Word already runs, without veering off into “quarrels about words” or “irreverent babble.” Hymenaeus and Philetus “swerved.” Timothy is to cut it straight.

Keep that picture in mind for the rest of this study. Every tool we are about to pick up has one purpose: to help you follow the line the Author drew, instead of drawing your own.

Part One: The Posture Before the Method



"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path" (Ps. 119:105). The light falls on the page, but it takes the Spirit to give us eyes.

Before you pick up a single tool, settle what kind of book you are holding. If the Bible were only a collection of ancient religious writings, the best you could do is study what some people once believed about God. But that is not what it claims to be.

2 Timothy 3:16–17 *"All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness, that the man of God may be complete, equipped for every good work."*

"Breathed out by God." Scripture is God speaking. Peter adds how it happened: "No prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit" (2 Pet. 1:21). Real men wrote, in their own languages and styles. God carried them along so that what they wrote is what he said. Two things follow for how we read.

First, we come to listen, not to sit in judgment. We do ask hard questions of the text, and we should. But the text has authority over us. We do not have authority over it. The Westminster Larger Catechism describes the right posture well. It says Scripture is to be read "with an high and reverent esteem of them; with a firm persuasion that they are the very Word of God, and that he only can enable us to understand them; with desire to know, believe, and obey the will of God revealed in them; with diligence, and attention to the matter and scope of them; with meditation, application, self-denial, and prayer" (WLC 157). Read that slowly. It is a whole Bible-study course in one sentence. Notice "attention to the matter and scope of them." The old divines meant the content and the purpose of a passage. That phrase alone covers half of what this study will teach.

Second, we need help we cannot supply ourselves. “The natural person does not accept the things of the Spirit of God, for they are folly to him, and he is not able to understand them because they are spiritually discerned” (1 Cor. 2:14). The problem Paul names is not low intelligence. Brilliant people have read the Bible and seen nothing in it. The problem is a heart that does not want what God says. So the first tool of interpretation is prayer. The Psalmist prayed, “Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law” (Ps. 119:18). On the road to Emmaus, after Jesus walked two disciples through Moses and the Prophets, Luke says “he opened their minds to understand the Scriptures” (Luke 24:45).

John Calvin has a picture for what Scripture does for us. He compared us to old people with failing eyes who can hardly make out two words on a page, until someone hands them glasses. Then they read clearly. Scripture, he said, “gathering together the impressions of Deity, which, till then, lay confused in our minds, dissipates the darkness, and shows us the true God clearly” (*Institutes* 1.6.1). The Bible is the lens. The Spirit is the one who puts it on your face.

One guardrail here, so prayer does not become a shortcut. The Spirit illumines the Word. He does not replace it. Praying over a verse and then deciding it means whatever came into your head is not illumination. The Confession is careful on this point: the Spirit’s inward illumination is “necessary for the saving understanding of such things as are revealed in the Word” (WCF 1.6). The Spirit opens your eyes to what is on the page. He does not whisper a second meaning that is not there. So pray, and then do the work.

Also read: *Psalm 19:7–11; 119:18, 105, 130; Luke 24:25–27, 44–45; John 16:13–14; 1 Corinthians 2:10–16; 2 Peter 1:19–21*

Part Two: A God Who Reasons

Here is a question most Christians never think to ask: why should the Bible make sense at all? Why should we expect one part of it to agree with another, or a sentence to mean the same thing on Tuesday that it meant on Monday? The answer goes all the way down to who God is.

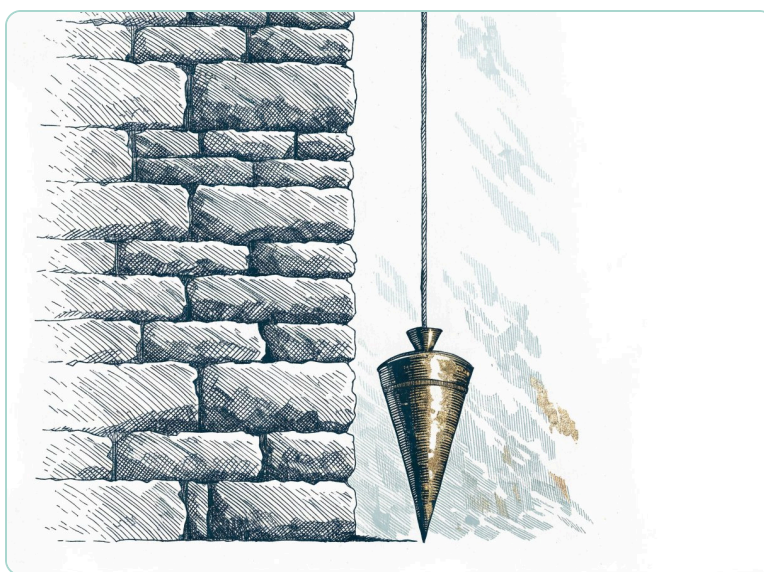
John 1:1 *“In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.”*

The Greek for “Word” is *logos*. In the ancient world it meant a spoken word, but also reason, account, the rational order of things. It is where we get “logic.” The Christian philosopher Gordon H. Clark, whose textbook *Logic* stands behind this part of the study, pressed the point hard. He argued that logic is not a rule outside God that God must obey, and it is not a human invention either. It is the way God himself thinks. In one essay he put it in five words: “The law is God thinking.” And he drew the conclusion that matters for Bible study: “if God has spoken, he has spoken logically.”

Clark was not the first to see this. Augustine, writing on how to interpret Scripture around AD 400, said that “the science of reasoning is of very great service in searching into and unravelling all sorts of questions that come up in Scripture.” Then he went further: “the validity of logical sequences is not a thing devised by men, but is observed and noted by them that they may be able to learn and teach it; for

it exists eternally in the reason of things, and has its origin with God" (*On Christian Doctrine* 2.31–32). Fifteen centuries apart, the bishop and the philosopher agree. Logic is not a lens the world invented and then pointed at the Bible. It comes from the same God who wrote the Bible.

Scripture shows this in how God speaks. "Come now, let us reason together, says the LORD" (Isa. 1:18). The Hebrew verb there (*yākaḥ*) is courtroom language, the word for arguing a case before a judge. God does not bully his people. He lays out the evidence and makes his case, and then offers astonishing grace: "though your sins are like scarlet, they shall be as white as snow." God also never lies (Titus 1:2), and it is "impossible for God to lie" (Heb. 6:18). That is a logical claim as much as a moral one. A God who cannot lie cannot say both "yes" and "no" to the same thing. Paul makes exactly that argument about his own preaching: "As surely as God is faithful, our word to you has not been Yes and No" (2 Cor. 1:18). And Jesus, settling an argument with his opponents, said simply, "Scripture cannot be broken" (John 10:35).



"Behold, I am setting a plumb line in the midst of my people Israel" (Amos 7:8). A plumb line does not argue with the wall. It just hangs true, and everything crooked shows.

Three laws you already use

Clark's *Logic*, like every traditional logic text, starts with what are called the three laws of thought. They sound abstract. You use all three every day without thinking about it. Here they are, with what each one means when you open your Bible.

Three Laws Every Reader Already Uses

1 Identity

A is A

A thing is what it is. A word means what it means in its sentence.

IN BIBLE READING

Read 'faith' in James 2 the way James uses it. Don't swap meanings halfway through.

Echo: Heb. 13:8

2 Non-contradiction

Not both A and not-A

Nothing is true and false in the same sense at the same time.

IN BIBLE READING

Two texts cannot truly clash. If my readings do, one of my readings is wrong.

Echo: 2 Cor. 1:18; Titus 1:2

3 Excluded middle

Either A or not-A

A statement is either true or false. There is no third option.

IN BIBLE READING

Jesus is Lord or he is not. The text presses a decision on every reader.

Echo: Matt. 12:30

The second law, non-contradiction, is the one that will save you the most grief. It means two true statements can never truly contradict each other in the same sense at the same time. So when two Bible passages seem to clash, logic does not tell you the Bible is broken. It tells you that at least one of your readings is wrong, and it sends you back to look harder. We will see exactly how that works in Part Six.

Clark also made a point about the limits of a certain kind of reasoning that is worth knowing. Reasoning from many examples to a general rule (what logicians call induction) can suggest a conclusion, but it can never prove one. You can watch a thousand white swans and still meet a black one. That has a direct use in Bible study: one story in Scripture is not automatically a rule for every believer. We will come back to it. For now, notice that people use the word "inductive" in two different ways. When a Bible-study book tells you to study "inductively," it usually just means: look carefully at the text first before you decide what it means. That is wise, and nothing in Clark argues against it. His warning was about trying to *prove* a universal truth from a handful of observations. Same word, two senses. Which, as it happens, is exactly the kind of thing the first law teaches you to watch for.

A fair word on a family disagreement

You should know that Reformed Christians have argued about this. In the 1940s Gordon Clark and Cornelius Van Til, both conservative Presbyterians, clashed over it in the Orthodox Presbyterian Church. Van Til stressed the Creator-creature distinction: God's knowledge is original and ours is derived, so we think God's thoughts after him by analogy. On that view, some teachings of Scripture can look contradictory to us, and we should accept them anyway. Clark answered that unless some truth we know is the same truth God knows, we do not really know anything. On his view, an apparent contradiction is a call to compare Scripture with Scripture until we see how it fits. Each man was guarding something precious. Van Til guarded the majesty of a God whose thoughts are higher than ours (Isa. 55:8-9). Clark guarded the fact that God has truly spoken and we can truly understand him (Deut. 30:11-14). This study

follows Clark on logic. It also confesses with both men that God is beyond our full understanding: “The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things that are revealed belong to us and to our children forever” (Deut. 29:29). Logic is the servant of revelation, never its master. It helps us read what God has said. It does not entitle us to demand what he has not.

Also read: *Numbers 23:19; Isaiah 1:18; 55:8–11; John 1:1–14; 10:35; 17:17; 2 Corinthians 1:17–20; Titus 1:2; Hebrews 6:17–18*

Part Three: Reasoning the Way Jesus and Paul Reasoned

If the Bible is logical, then reading it well means following its arguments the way its authors built them. The best teachers of this are Jesus and Paul themselves. Watch how they handle Scripture and you will see sound reasoning at work on almost every page.

Jesus argues from a verb tense. The Sadducees did not believe in the resurrection. They tried to trap Jesus with a riddle about a woman married seven times. He answered from the book of Exodus, which they accepted:

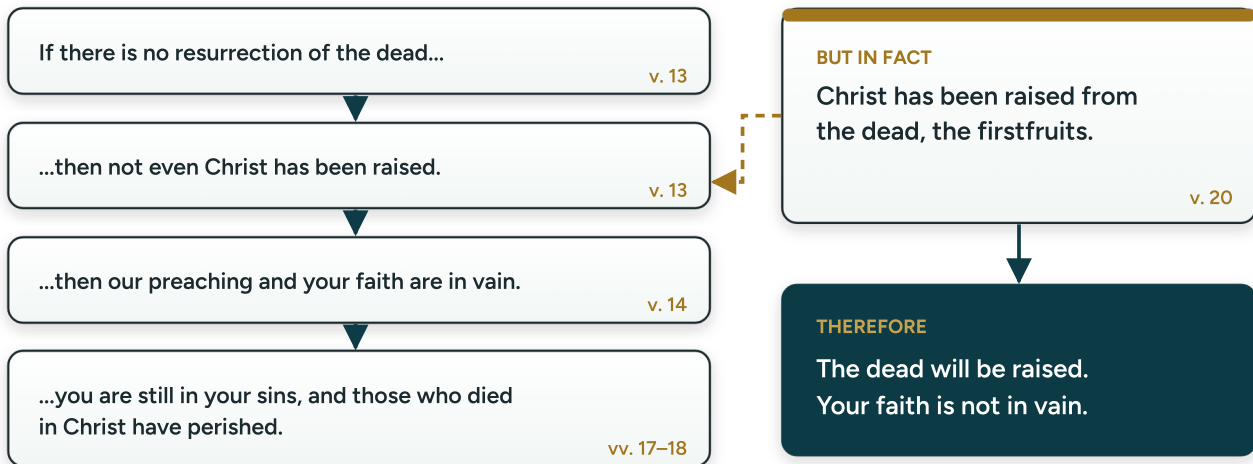
Matthew 22:31–32 *“And as for the resurrection of the dead, have you not read what was said to you by God: ‘I am the God of Abraham, and the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob’? He is not God of the dead, but of the living.”*

Lay the argument out and it is a clean syllogism. God is not the God of the dead, but of the living. God says, centuries after the patriarchs died, “I *am* their God.” Therefore Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob are living. The whole argument rests on one small word: *am*, not *was*. Jesus treated the precise wording of Scripture as reliable enough to carry the weight of a doctrine, and the crowd “was astonished at his teaching” (22:33). This is what the Westminster Confession means when it says the whole counsel of God is “either expressly set down in Scripture, or by good and necessary consequence may be deduced from Scripture” (WCF 1.6). Some truths are stated outright. Others follow necessarily from what is stated. The doctrine of the Trinity is the classic example. No single verse says “God is three persons in one essence,” but it follows necessarily from what many verses say.

Jesus argues from absurdity. When the Pharisees claimed he cast out demons by the power of Satan, Jesus showed that their position destroyed itself: “Every kingdom divided against itself is laid waste... And if Satan casts out Satan, he is divided against himself. How then will his kingdom stand?” (Matt. 12:25–26). Take their claim seriously, follow it out, and it collapses. Logicians call that a *reductio ad absurdum*. Jesus just called it common sense.

Paul argues in a chain. Some in Corinth were saying there is no resurrection of the dead. Paul does not simply contradict them. He follows their claim to where it leads.

How Paul Reasons in 1 Corinthians 15



If P, then Q. · Not Q. · Therefore, not P.

Deny the result and you have denied the starting point. Logicians call this modus tollens.

Augustine used this very passage to show that sound reasoning "has its origin with God" (On Christian Doctrine 2.32).

This is the logic Paul uses throughout his letters, and it is why words like "if," "then," "therefore," and "for" matter so much. They are the joints of the argument. One of the best habits a new believer can build is this: every time you see a "therefore," stop and ask what it is there for. It is pointing back at what came before. Romans 12:1 begins, "I appeal to you *therefore*, brothers, by the mercies of God." The "therefore" rests on eleven chapters of grace. Skip it and you turn the gospel upside down, making obedience the way to earn mercy when Paul made it the response to mercy.

Paul did this in his preaching too. In Thessalonica, "as was his custom, he went in, and on three Sabbath days he reasoned with them from the Scriptures" (Acts 17:2). The verb (*dialogomai*) gives us "dialogue." It means to argue a point back and forth. Peter tells every believer to be ready to do the same: "always being prepared to make a defense to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that is in you" (1 Pet. 3:15). The word for "reason" there is *logos*. The hope is not irrational. It has a reason, and you can give it.

Valid and invalid: how arguments go wrong

Clark's *Logic* spends a good deal of time on the difference between a **valid** argument and a **sound** one, and it is worth learning. An argument is valid when the conclusion really follows from the premises. It is sound when it is valid *and* the premises are true. You can have a perfectly valid argument with a false premise, and it will march you confidently to a false conclusion. So in Bible study you have to check both things: Is the premise actually what the text says? And does my conclusion actually follow from it?

Most of the reasoning in Scripture runs on "if... then" statements, and there are two right ways and two wrong ways to reason with them. The wrong ways feel right, which is what makes them dangerous. Look at the two invalid examples below closely. In the first one, Scripture itself warns you about the error.

Two Ways to Reason Rightly, Two Ways to Go Wrong

VALID

Affirming the "if"

If P, then Q · P · So, Q

"If you confess... and believe... you will be saved" (Rom. 10:9). You confess and believe. So you will be saved.

VALID

Denying the "then"

If P, then Q · Not Q · So, not P

If the dead are not raised, Christ is not raised. But Christ is raised. So the dead will be raised (1 Cor. 15:13, 20).

INVALID

Affirming the "then"

If P, then Q · Q · So, P?

A true prophet's word comes to pass (Deut. 18:22). This sign came to pass, so he's from God? Deut. 13:1–3 says no: test the message.

INVALID

Denying the "if"

If P, then Q · Not P · So, not Q?

Whoever won't provide for his own has denied the faith (1 Tim. 5:8). I provide, so I'm sound? The verse names one failure, not all.

Deuteronomy 13 is a remarkable passage for this reason. God tells Israel that a prophet might arise and give a sign, "and the sign or wonder that he tells you comes to pass," and then say, "Let us go after other gods." Do not listen, says the LORD, "for the LORD your God is testing you" (Deut. 13:1–3). A sign that comes true does not prove a prophet is from God. The Bible is teaching its readers not to affirm the consequent, long before anyone gave the mistake a name. That is exactly why the Bereans checked what they heard against the written Word.

Also read: *Matthew 12:1–8; 22:41–46; Acts 17:2–3; 18:4; Romans 6:1–4; 1 Corinthians 15:12–20; Galatians 3:15–18; Hebrews 7:11–17*

Part Four: One Meaning: the Author's



"They read from the book, from the Law of God, clearly, and they gave the sense, so that the people understood the reading" (Neh. 8:8).

After the exile, the people of Jerusalem gathered in the square by the Water Gate and asked Ezra to bring out the Law. He stood on a wooden platform and read from early morning until midday, and the Levites moved among the people helping them understand. Nehemiah describes what they did: "They read from the book, from the Law of God, clearly, and they gave the sense, so that the people understood the reading" (Neh. 8:8). That one verse is a job description for every Bible teacher and every Bible student. Read it clearly. Give the sense. Make sure it is understood. And the result was not a lecture hall full of informed people. It was weeping, then joy, then obedience (8:9–18).

"Gave the sense" assumes the text *has* a sense to give, one that was there before the reader arrived. This is the heart of what scholars call the grammatical-historical method: the meaning of a passage is what its author intended to communicate to his first readers, through the words and grammar he chose, in his historical setting. The Westminster Confession puts it in a short parenthesis that carries enormous weight. It speaks of "the true and full sense of any Scripture (which is not manifold, but one)" (WCF 1.9). One meaning. Not one for you and a different one for me.

That does not mean a passage has only one *application*. A single meaning can land in a thousand lives in a thousand ways. But the meaning itself is fixed, and every application has to grow out of it. Calvin said the interpreter's first task is to stay with the author. In the preface to his commentary on Romans he wrote that "it is almost his only work to lay open the mind of the writer whom he undertakes to explain."

The more a reader leads people away from the author's meaning, Calvin went on, the further he wanders from his purpose. John Owen, the great Puritan, said the same thing a century later: there is no other sense in a text than what is contained in its words.

Gordon Fee and Douglas Stuart, in their widely used *How to Read the Bible for All Its Worth*, give the principle a modern form that is easy to remember: a text cannot mean what it could never have meant to its original readers. If your reading would have made no sense to the Philippians or the exiles in Babylon, it is not the meaning of the text. This guards against a whole family of mistakes, including the very common one of reading the Bible as if it were written yesterday, to you, about your situation.

This principle also corrects a famous misreading. People often quote 2 Peter 1:20, "no prophecy of Scripture comes from someone's own interpretation," to mean that ordinary believers are not allowed to interpret the Bible for themselves. But read the next verse: "For no prophecy was ever produced by the will of man, but men spoke from God" (1:21). Peter is talking about where prophecy *came from*, not about who may read it. The prophets did not make it up. R.C. Sproul, who taught a generation of Christians to study Scripture, gave the balance this way in *Knowing Scripture*: private interpretation gives you a license to interpret, not a license to distort.

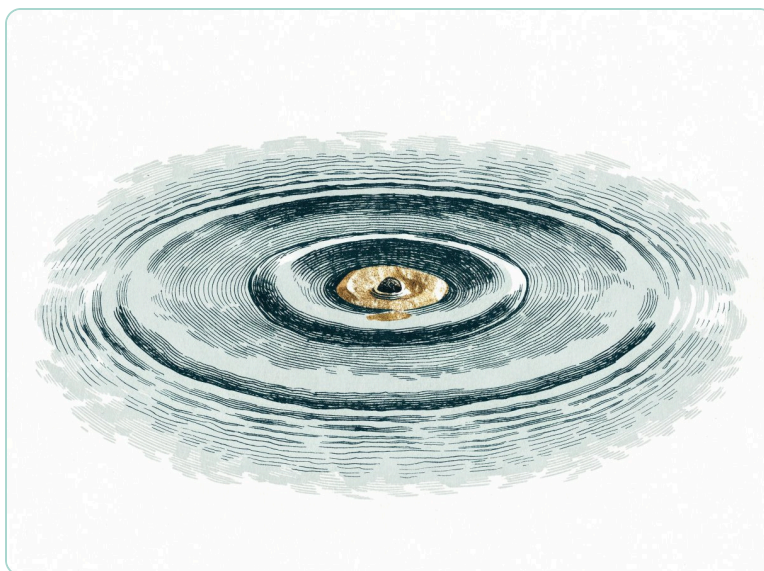
Read it for what it is

One more piece belongs here. To find an author's meaning, you have to know what kind of writing you are reading. Poetry, history, law, proverb, prophecy, parable, letter, and apocalyptic vision each communicate in their own way, and misreading the genre is one of the most common ways to miss the meaning. Sproul's ten practical rules of interpretation include several that are about exactly this:

- 1 **Note the parallelisms.** Hebrew poetry rhymes ideas, not sounds. "The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork" (Ps. 19:1) says one thing twice. Don't build two doctrines out of a single thought said in two lines.
- 2 **Know the difference between a proverb and a law.** "Train up a child in the way he should go; even when he is old he will not depart from it" (Prov. 22:6) is wisdom about how life usually works. It is not a guarantee, and it is cruel to treat it as one for a grieving parent.
- 3 **Be careful with parables.** A parable usually drives at one main point. Don't make every detail stand for something.
- 4 **Be careful with predictive prophecy.** Prophetic language is often vivid and symbolic, and Scripture's own fulfillments are the best guide to reading it (Acts 2:16–21).

Also read: *Nehemiah 8:1–12; Luke 1:1–4; John 20:30–31; 1 Corinthians 10:11; 2 Peter 1:19–21; Romans 15:4*

Part Five: Context: the Circles Around Every Verse

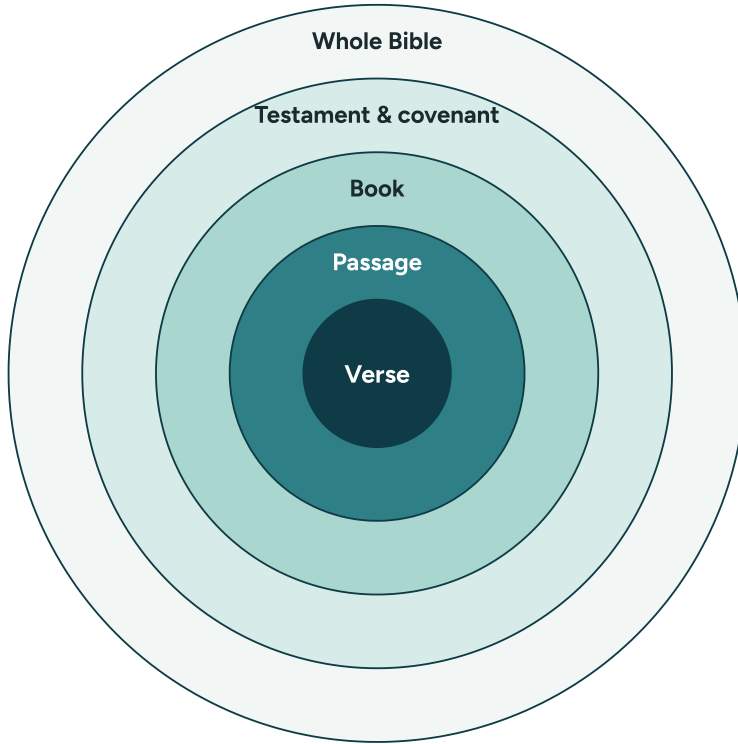


One stone, many rings. Every verse sits at the center of widening circles, and each circle helps tell you what the verse means.

If the author's meaning is the target, context is the map that gets you there. Augustine's advice for a difficult passage, sixteen hundred years ago, was simply this: "it remains to consult the context, both what goes before and what comes after" (*On Christian Doctrine* 3.2). That is still the single best piece of Bible-study advice ever given.

J.I. Packer described three layers of context. Every text has an immediate context in its own passage, a broader context in its book, and, in his words, "its ultimate context in the Bible as a whole." Add the history around the text and its place in the unfolding story of redemption, and you get a picture like this:

The Circles of Context



- **Verse**
What does this sentence say?
Grammar, key words, the verbs.
- **Passage**
What comes before and after?
Follow the argument or the story.
- **Book**
Who wrote it, to whom, and why?
What kind of writing is it?
- **Testament & covenant**
Where in redemptive history?
Before or after the cross?
- **Whole Bible**
What does all of Scripture
teach on this? Where is Christ?

Plus the history around the text: who, when, where, and what the first readers already knew.

Work from the inside out. Read the verse carefully. Then read the paragraph it sits in, and ask what the author is arguing or narrating. Then step back to the book: who wrote it, to whom, and why? Then ask where it falls in the story of redemption. Is this before Christ or after? Is it law given to Israel in the land, or a letter to a Gentile church? Finally, ask what the whole Bible teaches on the subject. The redemptive-historical circle matters more than new readers expect. Jesus himself said all of Scripture points to him: “beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself” (Luke 24:27). Every passage has a place on that road.

Here is what happens when you skip the circles. These four verses are among the most quoted in the Bible, and among the most often misread.

1 Jeremiah 29:11

OFTEN READ AS

“God has a plan to make my life go well, starting now.”

IN CONTEXT IT SAYS

God will keep his covenant with his exiled people, after seventy years in Babylon.

"For I know the plans I have for you, declares the LORD, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope." The verse just before it says, "When seventy years are completed for Babylon, I will visit you" (29:10). Jeremiah is writing to people who have just been dragged into exile, and he is telling them to settle in, build houses, plant gardens, and pray for the city, because they are not going home soon (29:4–7). Most of the adults reading that letter would die in Babylon. The promise is real, and it does reach us, because God's faithfulness to his covenant people runs all the way to Christ. But it is a promise of faithfulness through a long hardship, not a promise that the hardship will skip you.

2 Philippians 4:13

OFTEN READ AS

"With Jesus I can win the game, pass the test, close the deal."

IN CONTEXT IT SAYS

Christ makes me content whether I am full or hungry, rich or poor.

Read the two verses before it: "I have learned in whatever situation I am to be content. I know how to be brought low, and I know how to abound... facing plenty and hunger, abundance and need" (4:11–12). Paul is writing from prison. The "all things" he can do through Christ includes going hungry. The verse is not a promise of success. It is a secret of contentment, and that is a far better gift.

3 Matthew 18:20

OFTEN READ AS

"Jesus shows up when at least two of us pray together."

IN CONTEXT IT SAYS

Christ stands behind his church when it rightly deals with unrepentant sin.

"For where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I among them." The paragraph is about church discipline: going to a brother privately, then with "one or two others" as witnesses, then telling it to the church (18:15–17). The "two or three" echoes the witnesses required by the law (Deut. 19:15). Jesus is promising his authority and presence to the church as it does this hard work. He is present with his people in many ways. This verse is about one specific way.

4 Isaiah 28:10

OFTEN READ AS

"Precept upon precept, line upon line: God's method for teaching us."

IN CONTEXT IT SAYS

Drunken leaders mock Isaiah's preaching as baby talk, and God answers with judgment.

This one surprises people. Read verses 7–13. The priests and prophets of Jerusalem “reel with wine” (28:7), and they sneer at Isaiah: “To whom will he teach knowledge?... those who are weaned from the milk?” (28:9). In Hebrew, verse 10 is a string of short, sing-song syllables (*šaw lāšāw, šaw lāšāw, qaw lāqāw*). Most commentators hear them mimicking him, the way a child mocks a parent. God’s reply is that because they would not listen to plain words, he will speak to them through foreigners with “strange lips” (28:11), the Assyrian army. And the phrase comes back in verse 13 as a sentence of judgment: they will “go, and fall backward, and be broken.” A phrase many of us learned as a motto for Bible study is actually the sound of people refusing to listen. That is about as clear a lesson in context as Scripture offers.

In each case, the true meaning is richer than the misreading. Context never shrinks the Bible. It hands you the real thing.

Also read: *Jeremiah 29:1–14; Philippians 4:10–20; Matthew 18:15–20; Isaiah 28:7–16; Luke 24:25–27; John 5:39*

Part Six: Scripture Interprets Scripture



“They received the word with all eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily to see if these things were so” (Acts 17:11).

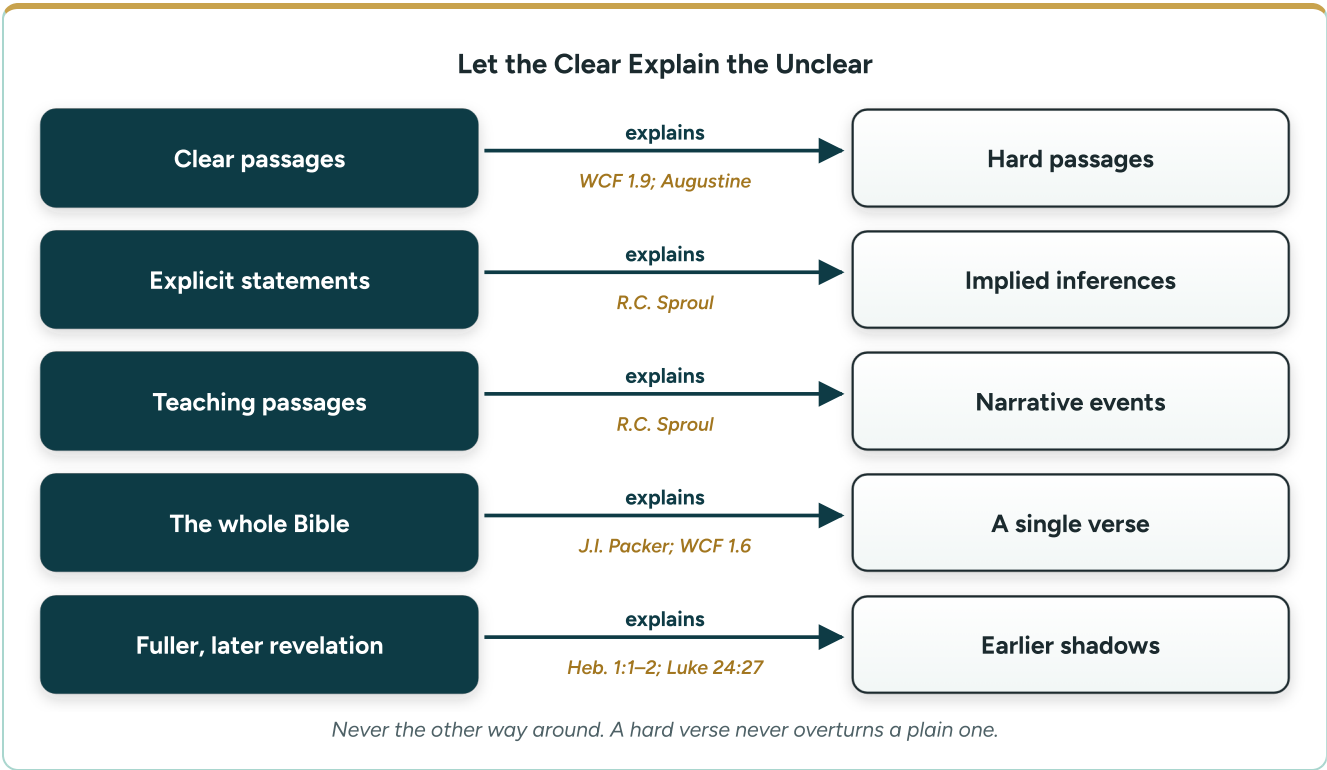
Now we come to the principle that holds all the others together. Because God is the ultimate Author of the whole Bible, and because he does not contradict himself, the Bible is its own best interpreter. This is not a Reformation novelty. Augustine taught it around AD 400: “draw examples from the plainer expressions to throw light upon the more obscure, and use the evidence of passages about which there

is no doubt to remove all hesitation in regard to the doubtful passages" (*On Christian Doctrine* 2.9). Martin Luther, arguing in 1520 that Scripture must judge even the church fathers, called Scripture "its own interpreter" (*sui ipsius interpres*). And the Westminster Confession made it the rule:

Westminster Confession 1.9 *"The infallible rule of interpretation of Scripture is the Scripture itself: and therefore, when there is a question about the true and full sense of any Scripture (which is not manifold, but one), it must be searched and known by other places that speak more clearly."*

Sproul called this the analogy of faith, and he insisted that if the Bible is truly God's Word, the analogy of faith is "not an option but a requirement." The Bereans practiced it. When Paul preached in their synagogue, they did not simply accept him because he was an apostle, and they did not reject him because he was new. They went home and opened the Scriptures, every day, "to see if these things were so." The verb Luke uses (*anakinō*) is the word for a judge examining evidence in a trial. And Luke calls them "more noble" for it (Acts 17:11).

In practice, the principle works out in a few simple rules about which passages explain which. Learn these five and you will avoid most of the errors that divide churches.



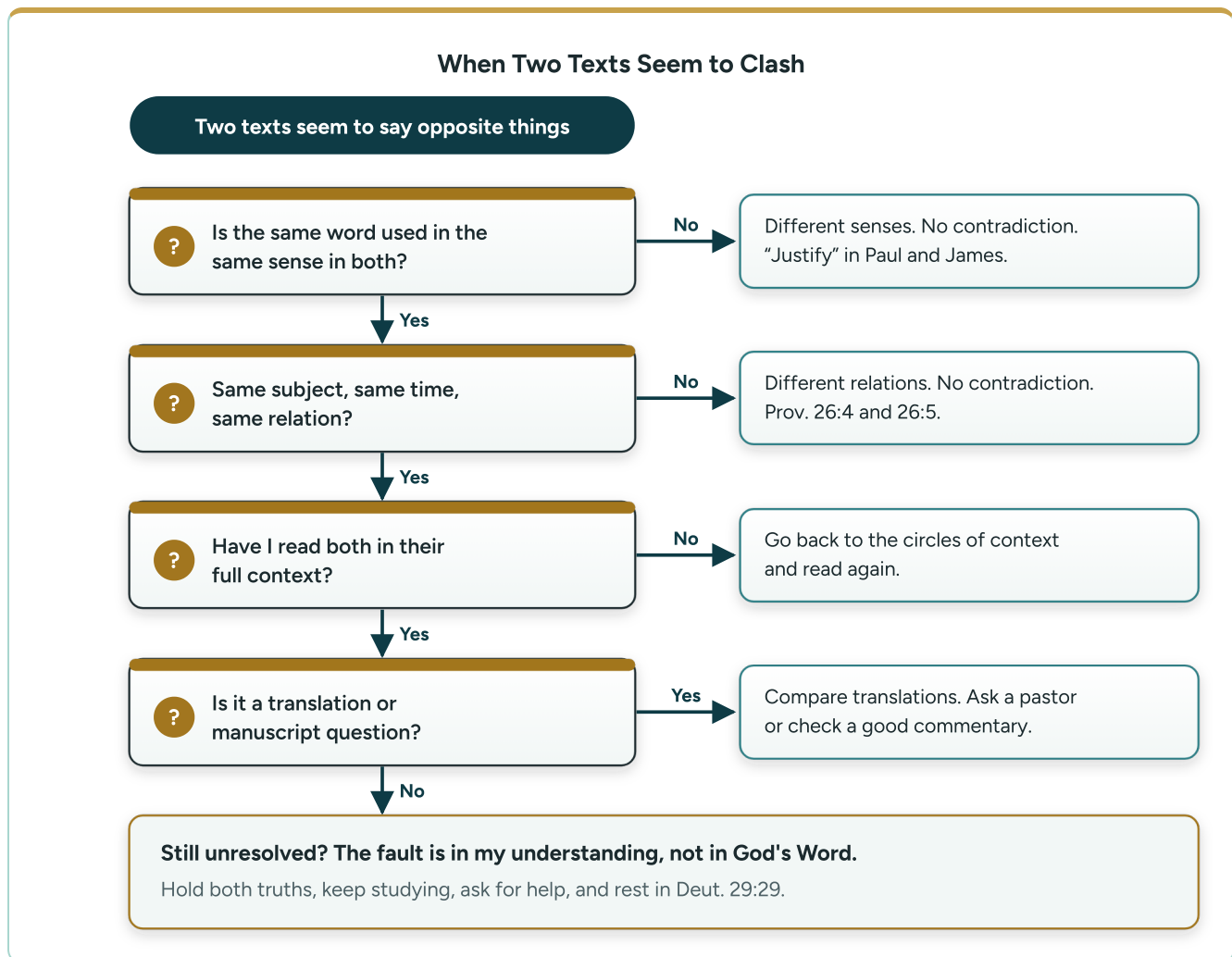
Two of those rules come straight from Sproul's list. "The implicit is to be interpreted by the explicit" means that when a verse only hints at something, you do not build a doctrine on the hint against a verse that says the opposite plainly. Sproul believed that this one rule, consistently followed, would settle the large majority of doctrinal disputes among Christians. "Historical narratives are to be interpreted by the didactic" means that a story tells you what happened, while teaching passages tell you what it means

and what God requires. This is where Clark's caution about induction pays off. In Acts 5, Ananias and Sapphira fall dead for lying. That does not mean God will strike every liar dead on the spot. Narrative reports. Teaching interprets.

The last rule, later revelation explaining earlier shadows, is how the Reformed tradition reads the Bible as one unfolding story. "Long ago, at many times and in many ways, God spoke to our fathers by the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son" (Heb. 1:1–2). The sacrifices, the temple, the priesthood, and the kings were real, and they were also shadows of the substance, which is Christ (Col. 2:17). The New Testament is God's own commentary on the Old.

When two texts seem to clash

Sooner or later every Bible reader finds two passages that seem to say opposite things. This is where logic and the analogy of faith work together. The law of non-contradiction tells you the two texts cannot both be true and false in the same sense at the same time, and God never lies. So you do not throw up your hands. You ask a few careful questions, in order:



The second question is easier to see with an example. Proverbs 26:4 says, “Answer not a fool according to his folly, lest you be like him yourself.” The very next verse says, “Answer a fool according to his folly, lest he be wise in his own eyes.” A contradiction? The editor who put them side by side obviously did not think so. They are about different relations: there is a way of answering a fool that drags you down to his level, and a way of answering that exposes his folly. Wisdom is knowing which moment calls for which. The apparent clash is the lesson.

The most famous case of all is the first question at work. It is the one that troubled Luther, and it still troubles new believers.

Worked Example: Romans 3:28 and James 2:24

Paul

Romans 3:28

“One is justified by faith apart from works of the law.”

His question

How is a guilty sinner made right with God?

“Justified”

Declared righteous by God the Judge (4:5)

“Faith”

Trust in Christ, the empty hand

“Works”

Law-keeping offered as merit

James

James 2:24

“A person is justified by works and not by faith alone.”

His question

What kind of faith is real faith?

“Justified”

Shown to be righteous (2:18, “show me”)

“Faith”

A bare claim: “if someone says” (2:14)

“Works”

The fruit that living faith bears

Same words, different senses, so no contradiction (the law of identity at work).

Paul shows the root: how we are declared righteous. James shows the fruit: how true faith is proved.

Faith is the alone instrument of justification, yet it is never alone (WCF 11.2).

Paul says we are justified by faith apart from works of the law (Rom. 3:28). James says we are justified by works and not by faith alone (James 2:24). If both writers meant exactly the same thing by “justified,” “faith,” and “works,” we would have a real contradiction. But they do not. Paul is answering the question of how a guilty sinner is declared righteous by God, and his answer is: through trusting Christ, not by earning it (Rom. 4:5). James is answering a different question: what kind of faith is real? He is dealing with someone who “says he has faith but does not have works” (James 2:14). That is a claim with no life in it, and James calls it dead (2:17). His proof is Abraham, who was declared righteous by faith in Genesis 15 and then, decades later, showed that faith was real by offering Isaac in Genesis 22 (James 2:21–23). Faith is the root. Works are the fruit. The Westminster Confession holds both together in one sentence: faith is “the alone instrument of justification: yet is it not alone in the person justified, but is ever accompanied with all other saving graces, and is no dead faith, but worketh by love” (WCF 11.2). Logic did not weaken Scripture here. It showed us how the two halves fit.

Also read: Acts 15:13–18; Romans 3:21–4:8; Galatians 3:6–14; James 2:14–26; Hebrews 1:1–4; Colossians 2:16–17; Proverbs 26:4–5

Part Seven: Errors That Bend the Text

It helps to know the common ways readers go wrong, the same way it helps a driver to know where the ice usually forms. D.A. Carson wrote a whole book on the subject, *Exegetical Fallacies*, and Clark’s *Logic* covers the informal fallacies as well. Here are eight that every new Bible reader will run into, most of them within the first month.

The error	What it looks like	The fix
Proof-texting	Pulling a verse out of its passage to support a point it was never making.	Read the circles. A verse means what it means in its paragraph.
Equivocation	Letting one word slide between two meanings mid-argument, like “justify” in Paul and James.	Define the word the way <i>this</i> author uses it <i>here</i> .
The root fallacy	Assuming a word’s “real” meaning is hidden in its parts or its origin.	Meaning comes from how a word is used in its own day (Carson).
Reading back	Pouring a later meaning into an older word: “power” (<i>dynamis</i>) means “dynamite.”	Dynamite came 1,800 years later. Ask what Paul’s readers heard.
Loading every meaning	Packing all a word’s possible senses into one verse at once.	A word in a sentence carries the one sense its context gives it.
False either/or	“Is this about God’s sovereignty or our responsibility?” when the text affirms both.	Ask whether the text forces a choice before you make one.
Story as rule	Turning one event in a narrative into a promise or command for everyone.	Let the teaching passages tell you what the story means.
The free association	A word sets off a personal memory or idea that has nothing to do with the text.	Ask, “Would the first readers have thought this?”

Notice how many of these are word mistakes. That is because words are the joints of meaning, and the joints are where things break. When you study a word, look at how the same author uses it elsewhere, then how the rest of Scripture uses it. A good concordance or a site like Blue Letter Bible will show you every place a Greek or Hebrew word appears. Let usage define the word. That is Scripture interpreting Scripture at the smallest scale.

And one warning about the spirit of all this. Augustine, right after praising logic, added that “in the use of it we must guard against the love of wrangling, and the childish vanity of entrapping an adversary” (*On Christian Doctrine* 2.31). Paul told Timothy the same thing in our key passage: “not to quarrel about words, which does no good, but only ruins the hearers” (2 Tim. 2:14). Learn these tools to read your Bible better, not to win arguments at small group. Augustine gave one more rule that sits over every other:

whoever thinks he understands Scripture, “but puts such an interpretation upon them as does not tend to build up this twofold love of God and our neighbor, does not yet understand them as he ought” (*On Christian Doctrine* 1.36). Sound interpretation always ends in love.

Part Eight: The Method, Step by Step

Now we put it all together. On our [How to Study the Bible](#) page we teach five steps, each with one question: Read, Interpret, Evaluate, Apply, and Correlate. Other good teachers compress the same path into three (Howard Hendricks called them observation, interpretation, and application; Jen Wilkin calls them comprehension, interpretation, and application). The names matter less than the order. You see what it says before you decide what it means, and you know what it means before you decide what to do with it. Here is the whole path, with the tools from this study attached to the step where you use them.

The Interpreter's Path: Five Steps and the Tools for Each

Before you start: pray (Ps. 119:18) and come to it as God's Word



Correlate sends you back to Read. The whole Bible keeps sending you back to the text.
Prayer before, humility throughout. The Spirit who wrote it is the one who teaches it.

Notice the gold diamond after Evaluate. That is the contradiction check from Part Six, built into the path. If your reading of a passage sets it against a clearer passage, you do not move on to application. You go back and interpret again. Many of the worst errors in church history came from people who skipped that diamond and applied a reading that never should have survived it.



"Do you understand what you are reading?" "How can I, unless someone guides me?" (Acts 8:30–31).

One more thing before the checklist. You were never meant to do this alone. An Ethiopian official was riding home from Jerusalem, reading Isaiah 53 aloud, and Philip ran up beside the chariot and asked if he understood it. His answer is one of the most honest lines in the Bible: "How can I, unless someone guides me?" (Acts 8:31). Philip "opened his mouth, and beginning with this Scripture he told him the good news about Jesus" (8:35). Christ gave his church teachers for exactly this reason, "to equip the saints... so that we may no longer be children, tossed to and fro by the waves and carried about by every wind of doctrine" (Eph. 4:11–14). Use them. Use a good study Bible, a solid commentary, your pastor, the men or women in your small group, and the historic confessions, which are the church's summaries of what the whole Bible teaches. Thomas Watson, the Puritan, advised readers to get what knowledge they can by comparing Scriptures, by talking with others, and by using the best commentators.

But keep them in their place. Teachers and confessions are helps. Scripture is the judge. The Westminster Confession is careful to put even itself under the Bible: "The supreme judge by which all controversies of religion are to be determined, and all decrees of councils, opinions of ancient writers, doctrines of men, and private spirits, are to be examined, and in whose sentence we are to rest, can be no other but the Holy Spirit speaking in the Scripture" (WCF 1.10). The Bereans checked Paul. You may check your pastor, and a good pastor will thank you for it.

The study checklist

Print this and keep it in your Bible. You will not need every question every time. Over a few months, you will find you are asking them without the list.

Step	Ask these questions
Pray	Have I asked God to open my eyes (Ps. 119:18)? Am I ready to obey what I find?
1. Read	Who is speaking, and to whom? What happens, where, and when? What words repeat? What is the main verb? What surprises me? What don't I understand yet?
2. Interpret	What kind of writing is this? What comes right before and after? What is the author arguing or showing? What does each key word mean as <i>this</i> author uses it? Where are the "if," "then," "therefore," and "for"? What would the first readers have understood?
3. Evaluate	Does my reading fit clearer passages on the same subject? Is my conclusion valid, or did I affirm the consequent or turn a story into a rule? What do faithful teachers and the confessions say?
4. Apply	What does this show me about God? About Christ and his work? About me? Is there a promise to believe, a command to obey, a sin to confess, an example to follow or avoid? What one thing will I do this week?
5. Correlate	Where else does Scripture teach this? How does it unfold through the covenants and land in Christ? Have I gathered the whole witness before settling my view?

Also read: Acts 8:26–40; 17:10–12; Ephesians 4:11–16; Hebrews 5:11–14; 2 Timothy 2:1–2; Psalm 1:1–3

The Turn: The Word Behind the Words

Everything in this study could be learned by someone who never comes to Christ. That is the sobering part. You can master context and grammar and logic, read the Bible with perfect technique, and still miss the point of the whole thing. Jesus said it to the most careful Bible students of his day:

John 5:39–40 *"You search the Scriptures because you think that in them you have eternal life; and it is they that bear witness about me, yet you refuse to come to me that you may have life."*

They searched. They were diligent. They knew the text better than most of us ever will. And they walked right past the Person the text was about. Bible study that does not end at Jesus has not finished.

Go back to where Part Two began. "In the beginning was the *Logos*." The reason and order behind every true sentence, the mind that makes logic logical, is not an abstract principle. John goes on: "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth" (John 1:14). The *Logos* has a face. The same God who will not contradict himself has kept every promise he ever made, and he kept them in his Son. "For all the promises of God find their Yes in him" (2 Cor. 1:20). That is the logic of the whole Bible. Every "if" in the law that condemned us, Christ answered with his obedience. Every "then" of judgment, Christ took on himself at the cross. And the "therefore" of the gospel is ours: "There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Rom. 8:1).

So come to the Bible the way the Bereans did, eager and careful. Cut it straight. Read the circles. Let the clear explain the hard. Follow the “therefore.” But read it the way the two disciples on the Emmaus road finally learned to read it, with burning hearts, because the Stranger walking beside them was opening the Scriptures and showing them himself (Luke 24:32).

Ezra gives us the right order to close on: he “set his heart to study the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel” (Ezra 7:10). Study. Do. Teach. In that order. And do not be afraid that you are too new or too untrained to begin. The Bible does not need you to defend it. Charles Spurgeon, preaching in 1886, pictured the gospel as a lion that some were anxious to protect. His advice was to open the door and let the lion out, because he would take care of himself: “the best ‘apology’ for the gospel is to let the gospel out.” Open the Book. It will take care of itself. And as you read it straight, it will take care of you.

Living It: Seven Practices

- 1 **Pray before you open it.** Every time, even if it is one sentence: “Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law” (Ps. 119:18).
- 2 **Read whole books.** Start with a short one like 1 John or Philippians and read the whole thing in one sitting, many days in a row. The book is the context. You cannot read the circles if you only ever see the center.
- 3 **Circle every “therefore.”** And every “if,” “then,” and “for.” Then draw an arrow back to what it points to. You will start seeing the arguments.
- 4 **Check your favorite verse.** Pick the verse you quote most and read the whole chapter around it. Ask whether it means what you thought. Usually it means more.
- 5 **Keep a question list.** Write down what you do not understand instead of guessing. Many questions answer themselves a few chapters later. Bring the rest to someone who can guide you (Acts 8:31).
- 6 **Run the contradiction check.** When two texts seem to clash, do not skip past it and do not panic. Walk the questions in Part Six. You will learn more from those passages than from almost any others.
- 7 **Do one thing.** End every study with one concrete act of obedience, however small. “Be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves” (James 1:22).

For Discussion

1. Before this study, how would you have described your “method” for reading the Bible? What has changed?
2. Paul says Hymenaeus and Philetus “swerved from the truth” by misreading a true doctrine (2 Tim. 2:18). Why can a bad interpretation of a true teaching be more dangerous than an obviously false teaching?

3. Why does it matter that logic comes from God rather than being a human invention? What would change about Bible study if it did not?
4. Which of the four misread verses in Part Five have you heard used the “often read as” way? How does the real meaning compare?
5. Walk through Romans 3:28 and James 2:24 together using the contradiction check. Which question settles it, and why?
6. The Bereans checked the apostle Paul against Scripture. What would it look like for you to be a Berean this week, kindly and humbly?
7. Jesus told careful Bible students that they searched the Scriptures but refused to come to him (John 5:39–40). How can you guard against studying the Bible without meeting Christ in it?

Sources & For Further Study

- **Text:** Deuteronomy 13:1–3; 18:22; 19:15; 29:29; 30:11–14; Ezra 7:10; Nehemiah 8:8–18; Psalm 19:1; 119:18, 105; Proverbs 3:6; 11:5; 22:6; 26:4–5; Isaiah 1:18; 28:7–13; 55:8–9; Jeremiah 29:4–11; Amos 7:7–8; Matthew 12:25–26; 18:15–20; 22:31–33; Luke 24:27, 32, 45; John 1:1, 14; 5:39–40; 10:35; Acts 2:16–21; 5:1–11; 8:26–35; 17:2, 11; Romans 3:28; 4:5; 8:1; 10:9; 12:1; 1 Corinthians 2:14; 15:12–20; 2 Corinthians 1:18–20; Ephesians 4:11–14; Philippians 4:11–13; Colossians 2:17; 1 Timothy 5:8; 2 Timothy 2:14–18; 3:16–17; 4:6; Titus 1:2; Hebrews 1:1–2; 6:18; James 1:22; 2:14–24; 1 Peter 3:15; 2 Peter 1:20–21; 3:16. English quotations follow the ESV.
- **Greek and Hebrew:** BDAG on ὀρθοτομέω (NT hapax; LXX Prov. 3:6; 11:5), στρεβλόω, διαλέγομαι, ἀνακρίνω, λόγος, δύναμις; LSJ on ὀρθός and τέμνω. HALOT on נָקַח (yākah), and the syllables יָקַח יָקַח יָקַח יָקַח in Isa. 28:10. Strong’s: orthotomeō G3718; streblōō G4761; dialegomai G1256; anakrinō G350; logos G3056.
- **Confessions:** Westminster Confession of Faith 1.6, 1.7, 1.9, 1.10, 11.2; Westminster Larger Catechism Q. 157; Second Helvetic Confession, ch. 2 (true interpretation is “gleaned from the Scriptures themselves”).
- **Older voices:** Augustine, *On Christian Doctrine* 1.36; 2.9; 2.31–32; 3.2; 3.26 (tr. J.F. Shaw, NPNF 1.2); Martin Luther, *Assertio omnium articulorum* (1520), WA 7:97; John Calvin, *Institutes* 1.6.1 (tr. Beveridge) and the dedication to the *Commentary on Romans* (tr. Owen); John Owen, *The Causes, Ways, and Means of Understanding the Mind of God*, Works 4; Thomas Watson, *How We May Read the Scriptures with Most Spiritual Profit*; Charles Spurgeon, “Christ and His Co-Workers” (sermon on Mark 16:20, 1886).
- **Logic:** Gordon H. Clark, *Logic* (Trinity Foundation) and the essay “God and Logic” (*The Trinity Review*, 1980). On the Clark–Van Til controversy, John Frame’s fair-minded treatment in *Cornelius Van Til: An Analysis of His Thought*, and Douglas Douma, *The Presbyterian Philosopher*.
- **Practical:** R.C. Sproul, *Knowing Scripture* (the best single book to read next); J.I. Packer, “Fundamentalism” and the Word of God, ch. 4; Gordon Fee and Douglas Stuart, *How to Read the Bible for All Its Worth*; Howard and William Hendricks, *Living by the Book*; Jen Wilkin, *Women of the Word*; D.A. Carson, *Exegetical Fallacies* (for leaders); Walter Kaiser, *Toward an Exegetical Theology* (for leaders).



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